CHAPTER 6

FEELING TORN AS A LEADER?

RECONCILE YOUR IDENTITIES TO MAKE YOUR WORK MORE MEANINGFUL

Summary

Professional and leader identities can conflict with or enhance one another with important consequences for leaders. The chapter proposes several questions that can help managers better understand the inner struggle that accompanies identity conflict and offers ways of overcoming it. The chapter then shifts to the idea of meaningful work, highlighting how identity conflict or enhancement can influence both leaders' and followers' sense of meaning Authenticity is presented as a crucial factor in finding meaning, closely tied to how leaders experience and manage identity conflict. The chapter concludes with suggestions about how organizations can help their leaders balance identities, feel authentic, and perceive their work as meaningful.

Chapter Outline

Luca. A Story of Conflict Between Professional and Leader Identity

Giovanni. A Story of Enhancement Between Professional and Leader Identity

Identity at Work

Identities in Conflict

What Can We Do About Identity Conflict and Enhancement?

- Identity conflict
- Identity Enhancement
- Action Planning

Meaningful Work

How Can We Make Our Work More Meaningful?

Feeling Authentic and Creating Meaning at Work

The Role of Authentic Leadership

Making Work Meaningful for Yourself and Your Team

What Can Organizations Do to Help Leaders Feel Less Torn?

Mindfulness

Mentoring and Coaching

Conclusions

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Be aware of how professional and leader identities are interconnected and understand how this relationship affects themselves and those they lead.
2. Understand that identity conflict and enhancement are perceptions that influence many aspects of employees' (both leaders and followers) lives at work.
3. Develop a deeper understanding of the complex connection between their identities, their sense of meaningful work, and authenticity.
4. Be able to reflect on their own identity conflict and enhancement, understand that they can address these challenges on their own or with support from their organization and learn about tools at both the individual and organizational level for managing identity conflict and enhancement.

Case Questions

Thinking of the **case of Giovanni**, the questions could be:

1) How does Giovanni experience his two identities (as a physician and as a leader?)

2) What helps him reconcile the two identities?

3) How does his reconciliation of the two identities help him become a better leader?

Thinking about the **case of Luca**, the questions could be:

1) How does Luca experience his two identities (as a physician and as a leader?)

2) Why does he view the two identities as conflicting?

3) How can Luca's experience of identity conflict influence his development as a leader?

Personal Development Activities

Tools and activities in the chapter

1) **Identity conflict**: answer the following three questions and reflect on them (see Navigating Leadership, pp. 106-107).
   - Write down 3‑4 key goals and objectives for your future development in professional and leadership roles in the next two years.
   - Are the goals of your professional and leadership roles listed above in conflict? Why is that? How does it make you feel? How does it affect your leadership practice and your overall work experience?
   - Do you often feel that you have to choose between following professional standards and doing what is best for your leadership role? Can you write down specific situations where you had to choose one over the other? How did that make you feel? How did it affect your leadership practice and your overall work experience?

2) **Identity enhancement**: answer the two following questions and reflect on them (see Navigating Leadership, pp. 107-108)

- Do you feel that your professional and leadership roles are in alignment and complement one another? How does this make you feel? How does it affect your leadership practice and your overall work experience?
- Do you feel that you can balance both your roles as a leader and as a professional? Can you write down a few specific experiences where you have reconciled these two roles? What did you do to achieve this? How did that make you feel? How did it affect your leadership practice and your overall work experience?

3) **Action Planning** (see Navigating Leadership, pp. 108-110)

Fill in the table below, starting with writing one of your developmental goals for reconciling identities at a time.

What are the key developmental goals that can help me reconcile identities?	*Who can help me achieve this goal?*	*What is the timeline for accomplishing this goal?*	*What personal and contextual resources do I need to accomplish this goal?*	*What are the expected individual and team outcomes?*
1.				
2.				

4) **How can we make our work more meaningful**? Answer the following questions and reflect on them (see *Navigating Leadership*, pp. 110-111):

- Do you feel that your work has meaning? What do you find meaningful about being a professional? What do you find meaningful about being a leader?
- Does your work help you understand yourself better? If yes, how?
- Do you think your work makes a positive difference to others? Who benefits from the work you do?

Additional recommended activities to work on this chapter

Before working on this chapter, it can be useful to have students think about examples of people with multiple identities, particularly how those identities intersect. To do this, collect stories that encourage students to reflect on how someone might balance a leader identity with a professional identity. For example, students could draw from personal experience or from people who are close to them who are working in contexts with strong professional identities—such as an architect leading an architectural firm or a chef managing a restaurant chain. Ask students to reflect on the following:

a) When these individuals talk about their work, do they focus more on their leadership role or their professional expertise?

b) Have they mentioned challenges or opportunities related to balancing their leadership and professional identities?

c) Do any of these stories highlight connections or tensions between the two roles?

This exercise will help students better understand the interplay of leader and professional identities.

After working on this chapter, it might be important to help participants think about how they experience the interconnection between their multiple identities and how this interconnection influences their work meaningfulness and perception of authenticity. If participants are professionals and leaders, we recommend sticking to those identities. If they are not, and the instructor is an expert on leadership and identity, it might be helpful to start a broader discussion that considers other identities that can conflict or enhance a leader identity (e.g., follower identity, gender or ethnicity).

After working on this chapter, ask everyone in the class to reflect on how they think that strengthening their leader and professional identity enhancement could improve their perception of work meaningfulness and their perception of being authentic while working. It

might be helpful to have them write down these reflections so that participants can go back and review them whenever they feel their work is less meaningful or they feel less authentic than usual. These links can also be good starting points for working on one's own identity enhancement.

Links to Other Chapters

- **Chapter 5**: leader self-complexity is linked to higher dissimilarity among one's roles (specifically different leadership roles) which is in turn linked to higher potential conflict among those roles and thus among one's identities.
- **Chapter 9**: liminality between identities (specifically leader and follower identities) and the feeling of being "betwixt and between" identities, typically when people face a role transition, is a state that can be associated with identity conflict. Also, the example of middle-managers – who are at the same time leaders and followers – is another case where multiple identities and a form of identity conflict can show up.

Key Reading

Harding, N. (2019). Identity and meaningful/ meaningless work. In R. Yeoman, C. Bailey, A. Madden, & M. Thompson (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Meaningful Work* (pp. 133‑147). Oxford University Press.

Pratt, M. G., Pradies, C., & Lepisto, D. A. (2013). Doing well, doing good, and doing with: Organizational practices for effectively cultivating meaningful work. In B. J. Dik, Z. S. Byrne, & M. F. Steger (Eds.), *Purpose and meaning in the workplace* (pp. 173–196). American Psychological Association.

Further Reading

Epitropaki, O., Kark, R., Mainemelis, C., & Lord, R. G. (2017). Leadership and followership identity processes: A multilevel review. *The Leadership Quarterly*, *28*(1), 104‐129.

Ramarajan, L. (2014). Past, present and future research on multiple identities: Toward an intrapersonal network approach. *Academy of Management Annals*, *8*(1), 589‐659.